

Common Defense Mechanisms

1. Denial
2. Projection
3. Regression
4. Acting out
5. Dissociation
6. Reaction formation
7. Avoidance
8. Compartmentalization
9. Repression
10. Displacement
11. Intellectualization
12. Rationalization
13. Undoing
14. Passive-aggression
15. Fantasy
16. Suppression
17. Sublimation
18. Compensation
19. Humor
20. Altruism
21. Aim inhibition

DEFENSE MECHANISMS PSYCHOLOGY

Defense Mechanism	Description	Examples
Repression	Pushing unacceptable thoughts into the unconscious	A person who experienced a traumatic childhood event has no recollection of it.
Denial	Refusing to acknowledge painful realities	A person diagnosed with a serious illness insists the doctors are wrong and avoids treatment.
Projection	Attributing one's negative feelings to others	Someone who feels insecure about their abilities criticizes others for being incompetent.
Displacement	Redirecting emotions from their original source to a safer target	After being reprimanded by their boss, an employee goes home and argues with their partner.
Rationalization	Creating logical but incorrect explanations	A student who fails a test blames the unfair difficulty of the questions rather than their lack of preparation.
Sublimation	Transforming negative impulses into socially valuable achievements	A person with aggressive tendencies channels their energy into becoming a competitive athlete.
Regression	Reverting to earlier developmental stages	An overwhelmed adult starts cuddling a childhood stuffed animal for comfort.